and protect against imitations, thus preserving their cultural heritage. Governments and NGOs play a significant role in raising awareness and promoting GI products. The Indian government, particularly through the **Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT)**, has launched **campaigns to educate artisans** and the public about the importance of GI tags. These efforts often involve **collaborations with local organizations** and use various media platforms to reach a broader audience.

The **One District One Product (ODOP)** program is a prime example of a government initiative that promotes **unique products from each district**, many of which are GI-tagged. ODOP aids in marketing these products, contributing to regional economic development and cultural preservation. The **G20 Summit** in India also served as an important platform for showcasing GI-tagged handicrafts and handlooms globally. Events like the Crafts Bazaar at the G20 Summit provided artisans an opportunity to exhibit and sell their GI-tagged products, enhancing international recognition and market access. Moreover, the **Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA)** plays a pivotal role in promoting GI products. APEDA's initiatives include organizing **international trade fairs, buyer-seller meets**, and **marketing campaigns** that help in enhancing the visibility of GI goods globally. Their focus on **innovative packaging**, quality improvement, and **market linkages** is instrumental in making GI-tagged products more appealing to national and international markets. NGOs complement these efforts by assisting artisan communities in GI registration, resource provision, and market access facilitation. They organize **exhibitions** and **promotional events** to create broader recognition and demand for GI products.

Global Recognition and Market Access

Geographical Indication (GI) tags have played a pivotal role in **elevating the international stature** of Indian handicraft items. These tags serve not just as markers of authenticity and quality, but also as **ambassadors of India's rich cultural tapestry on the global stage**. For instance, the Banarasi saree and Kancheepuram silk have transcended beyond mere products to become symbols of India's heritage, admired worldwide for their craftsmanship. GI tags help in **building a narrative** that **resonates with global audiences**, who increasingly value the story and tradition behind products. This enhanced recognition is crucial in preserving the legacy of these textiles while introducing them to new markets and generations, thus fostering an appreciation for the cultural history they embody.

The role of GI tags **in expanding market access for Indian handicraft** is multifaceted. Firstly, they provide a **competitive edge in international markets**, allowing these products to stand out amidst a sea of mass-produced goods. Consumers globally are more inclined to invest in products with a **certified mark of origin and quality**, which GI tags guarantee. This preference opens up lucrative export opportunities, contributing significantly to the growth of the Indian handloom sector. Furthermore, GI tags assist in **securing better trade terms** in international markets, as they ensure protection against imitation and misuse abroad. This protection is not just legal but also a **matter of prestige**, elevating the perceived value of these products. Consequently, artisans and weavers find new avenues for economic growth, as their products garner a premium in international markets. GI-tagged Indian textiles, thus, become **synonymous with quality and uniqueness**, driving demand and expanding their global footprint.

Government's Vision for Geographical Indications & Handicrafts Sector

Under the visionary leadership of **Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi**, the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) has embarked on a **robust strategy** to enhance Geographical Indication (GI) protection and support artisans in India's handloom sector, resonating with the ethos of **'Vocal for Local,' 'Local to Global,' and 'Aatmanirbhar Bharat.'**

The DPIIT has launched the 'Initiative for Promotion of GI (IPGI)' to foster awareness and support Indian Geographical Indication (GI) products with a substantial fund of Rs. 75 Crores allocated for the years 2022-25. This comprehensive initiative aims to amplify awareness of GIs across diverse levels, showcasing DPIIT's impactful role in promoting and safeguarding India's rich cultural heritage. The department's operational guidelines, designed to extend financial assistance to eligible agencies have supported various events, exhibitions, and other sensitisation and awareness programs conducted by central Government as well as various state Governments and other agencies. This initiative has yielded business opportunities to the grass root Authorised Users of GI by facilitating them buyers seller's meet, various fairs to showcase their products, onboarding them to digital platforms and several other benefits. The biggest outcome of the initiative is direct benefit to the ground level producers and weavers.

Another key initiative is the **extensive awareness campaign** about GI. The DPIIT is conducting educational programs and workshops across diverse artisan communities. These initiatives aim to deepen the understanding of GI's importance and guide artisans through the process of obtaining and maintaining these tags, thereby empowering them to leverage their unique heritage. Emphasizing the marketing and branding of GI-tagged products, the government is fostering **collaborations with e-commerce platforms** and ensuring participation in national and international trade fairs.

Moreover, the government is actively promoting the incorporation of traceability technology within the value chain of Geographical Indication (GI) products. In alignment with this initiative, SourceTrace, a SaaS organization, has introduced cutting-edge technologies on its DATAGREEN platform. These include Geo Mapping, Crop Management, Product Transfer, and Warehouse Management, utilizing QR Code and Barcode labeling to enhance the authenticity and quality assurance of GI-tagged products, including Darjeeling Tea. In terms of quality control, numerous efforts have been taken to maintain and verify the quality of products with GI tags. These include the promotion of GI-labeled products by Handicrafts Quality Control Council in Jammu and Kashmir through the use of GI and Non-GI QR Code-based labels for handicrafts, apart from imposition of strict actions for not complying with the rules. Furthermore, the Indian Institute of Carpet Technology (IICT) in Srinagar has implemented a meticulous certification process for the Kashmiri Hand Knotted Carpets, a renowned GI product. From physical inspection to laboratory testing, the process ensures adherence to quality standards as each certified carpet is assigned a unique QR labels.

Apart from this, Regular **monitoring and audits** are being conducted to uphold the high standards that GI tags represent, thus building a strong consumer trust base. **Financial empowerment of artisans** is another crucial aspect. The government is **facilitating easier access to credit and financial aid**, encouraging artisans to innovate while preserving traditional methods. This move is particularly significant in making the handloom sector competitive and self-reliant. Furthermore, **a strong legal framework to combat counterfeit and imitation products is being reinforced**. This involves stricter law enforcement and international cooperation to protect India's handloom heritage on a global scale.

Through these comprehensive initiatives, the DPIIT, under the aegis of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, is not only safeguarding the livelihood of artisans but also ensuring the handloom sector's sustainable growth. This vision is a testament to India's commitment to embracing its rich cultural legacy while marching towards an empowered and self-reliant future.